THRONE OF ASHES · VOLUME ONE

Throne of Ashes

Shadows of the Throne

CHAPTER TWO · THE SHIELD OF THE PHARAOH

READING COPY · DRAFT A

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This is a working draft of Chapter 2 of *Throne of Ashes*, Volume One. Chapter 1, “The Wish Beneath the Cherry Blossoms,” precedes it. Illustrations not yet included; one plate position is marked.

Set in Liberation Serif. Page size 6 × 9 inches.

CHAPTER TWO

The Shield of the Pharaoh

1

GAMES IN THE ROYAL CHAMBERS

“Sit with me. Sit with me.”

The Pharaoh of the Two Lands, Lord of the Thrones, Nebkheperure Tutankhamun, is patting the floor beside him with one small hand the way you’d call a cat.

I sit.

It is two hundred and twelve steps from my room to this one, with four turns, two of them left. I counted them behind Aneb's back while he walked too fast on purpose. A slave who is a head and a half taller than the king's new pet, and who wanted the pet to trot. I didn't trot. I counted.

They see a child. Let them see a slow one.

The bedchamber is the first soft place I have found in this palace. The walls are painted with reeds and birds, a marsh that goes all the way around the room, so the bed sits in the middle of it like a boat. A real bed, on carved lion's feet, with linen heaped on it. Heavy curtains hang over the far wall from ceiling to floor. The afternoon comes in through the high windows in long bars, and dust turns inside them, slow and gold.

Two guards stand on either side of the door. They haven't moved since I came in. I've been timing their breathing.

"You know senet," Tut says.

"No, Majesty."

"Good." He pushes the board between us. "Learn slowly."

He said it to me last night with a rope on my wrists and a dead man's blood still drying on the floor between us. He says it now the same way, flat, like a thing that has been true for a long time.

The board is a box of dark wood with thirty squares cut into the lid, three rows of ten. Five pieces each, his cones and my spools. He throws the sticks to show me, four flat sticks that clatter and come up two dark, two pale.

"Two," he says, and moves a cone.

I throw. Three. I move the wrong piece, and he reaches over and moves the right one for me without a word.

Aneb has not sat down. He stands at the head of the bed with his arms folded, and he watches me the way you'd watch a strange dog that has gotten near a baby.

He is the one who came for me at noon. He is tall and lean and dark, with black hair parted to one side, and a burn scar that runs across his face from his left temple to the right corner of his jaw, pale as a cut in bark. His linen is undyed and plain. No collar, no ring. Nothing on him that anyone would bother to steal. When he opened my door he said one word, “Boy,” and then turned and walked, and that was the whole of our conversation.

He’s eighteen, I’d guess. My age.

I lose the first game in a very long time, because it takes me most of it to understand the rules.

I lose the second game in exactly the right amount of time, and that is harder.

There are only three things you need to know about senet. The sticks decide how far you go; the board decides where it hurts; the rest is counting, and counting is the one thing this body didn’t take from me. By the middle of the second game I can see four throws ahead, and the whole problem becomes losing in a way that looks like a boy who is trying.

I let him send my spool back to the House of Water. He laughs.

It comes out of him all at once, a high crack of a laugh, and he claps his hand over his mouth as if someone might hear it from the hall and come to take it away. His eyes go to the door. Then to Aneb. Then, slowly, back to the board.

“Again,” he says.

A nine-year-old, I think, *who checks the door before he laughs.*

That is the thing I keep forgetting, and that I can’t afford to forget: nobody in this room is what they look like. He looks like a little boy in a gold collar with his thumbnail bitten to the quick. He is a god, or the Two Lands say he is, and a god with a seal. Last night that seal was the only thing between me and the scale.

He throws. He moves. He bends over the board with the whole of his small body, and under the gold collar he is thin, narrow across the shoulders, built out of wire and stubbornness. There are shadows under his eyes that don't belong on a face that age.

I know those shadows. I had them at ten too. Mine came from reading under the blanket with a flashlight. I don't think his did.

A dish comes in on the hands of a serving girl who keeps her eyes on the floor: a bowl of roasted quail eggs, small and speckled, with a saucer of salt and crushed cumin beside them. She sets it down between us and goes out backward.

Tut takes one, rolls it in the salt, and eats it in two bites.

I don't touch them.

He notices on the third egg. He notices most things, I'm learning. He just doesn't say.

"You don't eat."

"I am waiting for Your Majesty to finish."

"Why?"

Because the last boy who sat here lasted eleven days, and nobody has told me how.

"Where I come from, Majesty, a guest waits."

"Where you come from," Aneb says from the bed, "they have hair like wheat and the manners of a scribe's grandfather, and nobody has ever heard of it."

"East," I say, without turning around. "Herders. A long way."

"Herders." He makes the word sound like something stuck to a sandal.

"I was robbed on the road to the city. I came here with nothing."

"You came here with a piece of foreign paper and a mouth."

"Aneb." Tut doesn't look up from the board. It isn't loud. It's barely a word at all.

Aneb shuts his mouth. His jaw works once, and he looks away at the painted marsh on the wall as if he's counting the birds.

"Aneb tastes everything," Tut tells me. "Before it comes to me. Since I was four."

I look at the tall slave with the ruined face, who has just been told to be quiet by a child, and who did it. He has been putting strange food in his mouth for this boy for five years, every dish, every day, waiting to find out whether he dies. There is a kind of loyalty that is only a different word for being owned. I don't know yet which kind his is.

"Then he has tasted," I say. "And Your Majesty has eaten. And now I will."

I take an egg. It's good. It's the first thing I've eaten since the cherry road.

I didn't eat Hori's bread. I sat up all night with it on the mat beside me, listening to the bar on the door and the grain falling in the glass against my hip, and when the window slit went gray I scratched a line on the wall beside the last boy's ten and a half, and I rubbed out the map I'd drawn in the sand under the mat, and I was still hungry. Hungry is better than eleven days.

One. Seven hundred and twenty-nine to go.

I eat a second egg because the first one was fine and because Tut is watching me do it, and something in his face eases, as if I'd passed a test he didn't know he was giving.

We play again. I throw a four and move a spool onto a square that lets him trap it, and he sees it, and his mouth twitches. I'm getting better at losing. It's a skill. I had a fencing coach who said the hardest thing to teach was a boy who could already hit, how to miss on purpose so the other boy would come in. I was that boy. I'm that boy again, except now the other boy is a king and the point of the game is my throat.

While he thinks, I look at the room.

Under the heaped linen at the foot of the bed, half hidden, is a small carved boat. Wood, old, the paint worn off where a hand has held it. The only toy in a room built for a king.

High in the ceiling, in the corner over the curtains, a bronze grate covers a vent. A square of darker dark. The lamps aren't lit yet, and the daylight doesn't reach it.

The guards at the door breathe nine times a minute. I've been through it twice.

Tut moves his last cone off the board and sits back on his heels.

"I win."

"Your Majesty wins."

"You lost slower that time."

"I am learning slowly, Majesty. As I was told."

He looks at me for a while with his dark eyes, and I let him look. Then he takes another egg and rolls it in the salt, and the corner of his mouth goes up, and he doesn't check the door first.

Something in my chest I haven't felt since the fire lets go a little.

Two years, I think. *Seven hundred and twenty-nine days of this. A floor to sit on. A boy who wants to play. A game I can count.* I have survived worse rooms. I survived a six-mat room over a dry cleaner's with the rent paid by the ward office. Maybe this is what the god meant. Maybe a second childhood doesn't have to be the first one over again.

The afternoon light has climbed the far wall and gone orange on the curtains.

Behind the curtains, where there is no door, a shadow moves. ## 2 · The Assassin

The curtain opens the way a mouth opens.

A man comes out of it. Bare chest, a servant's kilt, palace sandals, a knife held point down along his forearm the way a man holds a knife when he has used one before. He does not shout. He does not say the

name of a god. He comes across the painted marsh at a run, and the only sound is his sandals on the plaster.

I have been in rooms with blades for nine years. Tournaments, salles, a coach who liked to come in low and fast to see if you'd flinch. My body knows what to do when steel comes at it. It knows how to give ground on the back foot, how to take the line, how to make the other man's speed into his mistake.

My body is ten years old.

Nothing happens. I sit on the floor with a wooden spool in my fingers and I watch him come, and my legs are two sticks somebody else owns.

Move.

I don't.

The guards at the door turn their heads. Both of them, together, like a thing on a hinge. Aneb is already running, from the bed, with his hands empty and his mouth open, and he is too far, and he knows it.

Tut doesn't look up.

He is holding one cone between two fingers over the square he was going to move to. He looks at the board. The man's shadow goes over him and over the board and over me.

The knife comes down toward the gold collar.

And stops.

A hand's width from the boy's chest, the point stops in the air, and the man's eyes go, not to the king, but past him, to the door.

Then the door is full of Nakhtmin.

I don't see him cross the room. One moment the door is empty and the next the Commander of the Royal Retainers is there with a khopesh in his hand, the curved bronze catching the orange light, and the next moment after that the blade has gone in under the man's jaw and across.

It is not quick. I thought it would be quick.

The man's head goes back. The knife falls out of his fingers and bounces once on the senet board and sends the cones everywhere. He puts both hands to his throat as if he could hold it closed. He can't. It comes through his fingers, dark and thick and more of it than you would think a man had, and it goes down his chest and onto the plaster, and onto the painted reeds, and a bird on the wall behind him is suddenly red.

He goes down on his knees first. Then onto his side, across the board, with his face a foot from mine.

He is trying to breathe. The sound it makes is a sound I will hear for a long time, a wet pulling, in and in and in, and bubbles at the cut. His eyes are open. He's looking at me, or at the place where I am. His sandal heel scrapes the floor, scrapes it, scrapes it, slower.

I watch him the whole way. I watched the old man last night and I watch this one now. It seems like the least I can do.

It takes him about as long as a game of senet.

Then the heel stops.

Nakhtmin wipes the khopesh on the dead man's kilt, twice, one side and then the other. He is broad through the shoulders and young, younger than the Vizier's officers, with a scar along his jaw and black hair pulled back so hard it looks painful. His eyes are older than the rest of him. They go once around the room, the curtain, the window, the grate, the guards, me, and come to rest on the king.

"Majesty."

"I'm not hurt."

"Majesty." A breath. "The Vizier will want to see him."

"Take him, then."

"It will be done."

He says it like a door closing. The two guards come off the wall at last and take the dead man by the ankles. They drag him out through the door and his arms trail behind him over his head, and his open eyes go

over the threshold last, and the blood makes a wide smooth road behind him across the floor.

Nakhtmin goes to the curtain and pulls it back. Behind it there is a narrow door in the plaster, plain, unpainted, servants' height. He looks at it for a while. Then he lets the curtain fall and follows the body out, and I hear him in the corridor giving orders in a voice that doesn't rise.

Aneb is standing in the middle of the room with his hands out in front of him as if he's still running.

They're shaking. He looks at them like they belong to someone else, and then he puts them behind his back and goes to the bed and stands at the king's shoulder, and after a moment he puts one hand on it. Tut lets him.

"You ran at a knife," I hear myself say, "with nothing in your hands."

"I'm a slave, boy." His voice is low and even, and his jaw is tight enough to crack. "I'm not a wall. He's—" He stops. He looks down at the top of the king's head. "Even pharaohs bleed sand," he says, quieter. "Somebody has to watch the door."

"The Commander watches the door."

"The Commander watches the Vizier's door. I watch this one."

File that.

Tut puts his cone down on the board, carefully, on the square he was going to move to. There's blood on the board. There's blood on the square. He sets the cone in it.

"You didn't move," he says to me. "When the man with the knife came. Everyone moves."

"You didn't move either."

"I'm used to it."

I look at the board. The spools have gone under the bed. One of my pieces is lying in the blood on its side.

"That's the third this season," Tut says. "Your turn."

I pick up the spool. I put it where it was. My hand will not stop shaking, and I let it shake, because the king has just told me that everyone moves and he has decided I am the exception, and a boy who doesn't move doesn't shake either, and I would rather he saw the hand than the truth.

"Pharaoh." I keep my voice down where his is. "Who sent him?"

"Someone who loves me very much, probably." He throws the sticks. Three. "They all say they do."

"He froze," Aneb says over the top of his head, to nobody. "The pet. He sat there like a stone and let the man come."

"He didn't move," Tut says, as if it were the same sentence.

It isn't. I know what my body did. Aneb knows what my body did; he's eighteen in an eighteen-year-old's body and he knows exactly what it is to be too slow. The king, who is nine, saw a boy who didn't flinch while his slave flinched for him, and I can see him deciding what it means, and I can see that I'm going to be allowed to let him.

They see a child. One of them sees a brave one. It's a start.

The third this season.

I sit on the floor of the only soft room in the palace and I count. The season is sixty days, if I have the calendar right, and I have the calendar right, because my mother drew it on the wall over my bed when I was seven. Three men with knives in sixty days. The old fan-bearer last night, for asking a question. Whoever had my room before me, eleven days.

If this is how the king lives, with his guards on the wall and the Shield of the Living Pharaoh one door away, then what happens to the king's foreign pet, who has no guards, no shield, no name anyone here can say without looking at him sideways, and who sleeps behind a bar that locks from the outside?

I don't know who that man was. I don't know who the Vizier's officers are, or why the High Priest looked at the Vizier before he read

the scale, or where the little door behind the curtain goes, or who has a key to it, or what a man with a knife wants when he stops.

Because he stopped. I was a foot away, and I saw it. The point stopped a hand's width from the gold collar, and his eyes went to the door, and then the khopesh came. In that order.

A man who wants a king dead does not stop to look at the door.

I don't know what that means. I know that I don't know, which is the only thing I've learned since the cherry road that's been worth anything.

In the knot of my kilt, against my hip, a grain of gold sand lets go of the glass.

I need someone who knows how this palace works. And I need him before the fourth. ## 3 · Finding the Raven

They take the king away to be washed.

That is what happens here after a man dies in your room, I learn: two priests with shaved heads and a bowl of natron come in, and a physician, and the king is lifted up off the floor by people who do not ask him, and carried out through a door I hadn't noticed to be purified of something. A serving girl is already on her knees with a cloth and a bucket. The water in the bucket goes pink and then brown. The red bird on the wall stays red.

"Go," Tut says to me over the physician's shoulder, in his flat voice. "Tomorrow."

Aneb walks me out.

He doesn't walk too fast this time. He walks like a man who has just run at a knife and is still finding out whether his legs are his. In the corridor he stops, and I stop, and the bar of light from a window slit lies between us on the floor.

"I need to ask you something," I say.

"Ask the king. You're his."

"The king is nine."

That gets me a look. The scar pulls his face slightly to one side when he frowns, so that half of him is angry and the other half is only tired.

“Who in this palace knows how it works,” I say, “and has no reason to lie to a toy?”

He doesn’t answer right away. I watch him decide whether I am worth the breath.

“The Raven,” he says finally. “Go and ask the Raven. He likes strays.” He jerks his chin down the corridor. “Second court, past the kitchens. The House of Life. Follow the ink. If the ink runs out, follow the wine.”

“Who is the Raven?”

“The old king’s pet.” He’s already walking away, back toward the room with the red bird in it. “You two should get along.”

He wants me away from the king, I think, watching his back. *And he’s just told me something true to do it. Both of those are useful.*

I go to find the Raven.

✦ ✦ ✦

Two hundred and forty steps. Seven turns. The kitchens announce themselves before I get to them, smoke and onions and a woman’s voice telling someone he is the son of a donkey, and after the kitchens the corridor narrows and the walls stop being painted and start being just walls.

The House of Life is a long low room with a garden on the other side of its windows. Shelves run from floor to ceiling, and on the shelves are jars, and in the jars are rolls of papyrus, hundreds of them, each with a little tag of leather hanging out. The dust is the dust of things that have been written down and then left alone. It smells of ink and reed and, under that, sour wine.

One man is in it.

He sits cross-legged at a low table with a roll open in front of him and a reed pen in his hand, and he is copying something, line by line, from an older roll onto a newer one. He is a big man, broad in the shoulders in a way that doesn't go with the pen, and he stoops over the table as if whatever he is carrying on his back has been there a long time. His hair is gray, and he isn't old enough for it to be gray, and it's tied back in a soldier's tail. His feet are bare. His fingers are black with ink to the second knuckle.

His left eye is a seam of scar tissue, closed for good. The right one is green.

There is a cup of wine by his elbow. It's the middle of the afternoon.

"The king's toy," he says, without lifting his head. His voice is smooth and low and formal, the voice of a man reading aloud from something written a long time ago. "Did he lose you? Or did you lose him?"

"Neither, my lord. I was told you know this palace."

"Who told you?"

"A slave."

"Then you've learned one thing already, and I didn't teach it to you." The pen moves. "The slaves know everything, and nobody asks them."

I wait. He lets me wait. He finishes a line, dips the pen, starts another.

"The pharaoh's court devours the naive," he says to the papyrus. "If you wish to outlast the boy who had your room before you, you will have to learn to smile while the knife finds another man's back. It is a thing that can be learned. I don't know that it can be taught." Now the green eye comes up and finds me, and it does not go up and down me the way everyone else's has. It goes straight to my face and stays. "And why would I teach a foreign child? What is in it for me? A child forgets by supper. A foreign child is dead by the flood."

“I don’t want to learn to smile.”

“No?”

“I want to know why a man with a knife stops.”

The pen stops.

He sets it down across the roll, carefully, so the ink won’t run, and he puts his two black hands flat on the table, and he looks at me with his one eye for the time it takes the dust to turn over once in the window light.

“Tell me what you saw.”

So I tell him. The curtain. The man who didn’t shout, who held the knife along his forearm like someone who had used one. How he came across the room at a run with no sound but sandals. How the point stopped a hand’s width from the gold collar, and the man’s eyes went to the door, and then the Commander’s blade came, in that order and not the other.

“A man who means it doesn’t stop, my lord. He finishes. A man who stops wants to be seen trying.”

“Seen by whom?”

“I don’t know.”

“And who did they blame?”

“Nobody has said.”

“Nobody will say it to you. By supper it will be a Hittite. Or a man of the Heretic’s household. Or a priest of some god nobody has prayed to for a generation. Whichever name is useful this month.” He picks up the cup, looks into it, puts it down without drinking. “So. Which name is useful this month?”

“I don’t know that either.”

“Good. You’ve said *I don’t know* three times, and you are the first person in this room in a year who has. Everyone else who comes in here knows everything.” He leans back. “The man is dead. His blood is real. Did the king’s heart beat faster?”

I think of the cone, set down carefully in the blood on the square.

"No."

"No. Because it was the third this season. One in the garden, one in the bath, and now one at the game board, and each one a man nobody knew, cut down before he could say who sent him. Does a play need to be false to work, child? Or does it only need to be repeated?"

"Then what is it for?"

"What is fear for?"

I don't answer that. I've been afraid for two days. I know exactly what it's for.

"Who taught you," he says, "to watch a man's eyes while he dies?"

"No one. I watched."

"Where did you learn to speak like this? Herders don't."

"I listened to old men."

He laughs, once, a short bark that doesn't reach the eye. "That I believe." He turns the copper ring on his finger. "Why do you want to live? Everyone who comes through that hall wants not to die. It isn't the same thing. Why do *you* want to live?"

Because the god gave me two years and I'm not spending them on a mat behind a bar. Because there's a boy on a throne who checks the door before he laughs and I know how old he'll be when they put him in the ground. Because my mother said a thing to me with her last breath and I still don't know what it meant.

"Because I owe a debt," I say.

He looks at me a long time.

"Everyone in Kemet owes a debt," he says. "The river collects. The Nile remembers what men forget." He picks up the pen again. "Come to the hall tonight. The court dines when the lamps are lit. Sit where the king puts you. Watch where I look. If you can tell me afterward what you saw, I will teach you. If you can't, then you'll have learned

something anyway, and it won't matter, because you'll be dead by the flood."

"And the price, my lord?"

"Ah. He asks the price." The pen goes back to the line it left. "I don't take students for nothing. The price is this. When I ask you a question, you answer it true. Lie to the king. Lie to the Vizier. Lie to the gods, if you can find one that's listening. Not to me."

"Yes, my lord."

I am going to break that before the lamps are lit. I know it as I say it. I've been lying since I woke up in the alley, and the lie is the only thing keeping the Weighing of the Heart on the other side of the door. I'll lie to this man too. I'll just have to be better at it than I've been at losing.

"They call you the Raven," I say at the door.

"They call me many things. That is the one they say to my face." He doesn't look up. "Two hundred and forty steps back, child. Seven turns. Try not to be killed on any of them."

I stop with my hand on the frame.

I hadn't said the number out loud. I'm certain I hadn't.

"Go," says the Raven of Kemet, and dips his pen. ## 4 · A Common Occurrence

The soldier who comes for me at lamplight is Hori.

I know him by the way he fills the door: the one who pulled me out of the river mud with one hand, who whispered the court's names at my shoulder with a rope in his fist, who dropped a loaf on my mat and told me how long the last boy lasted. He looks at me as if I'm a parcel he's been told to carry twice.

"The king sends for his pet."

"You brought the bread," I say.

"I was told to."

That's all. He walks and I follow and I count, and I think about the two ways a man can be told to feed a prisoner.

✦ ✦ ✦

The court dines in a long hall of columns with the lamps already burning, hundreds of them, in bronze dishes along the walls and on stands between the low tables, so the whole room is the color of the inside of a honey jar. Lotus flowers float in bowls of water on every table. Three harpists sit in a ring of light at the far end and play something slow that goes around and around. The air is roast goose and figs and perfume cones melting on the heads of the guests, sweet fat and wax, and under all of it the myrrh, which I love, which I will never again be able to smell without thinking of this night.

The king sits at the head of the hall on a raised seat with a footrest his feet don't reach.

I sit where he puts me, on a cushion on the floor at his feet, like a dog that has been allowed into the house. Aneb stands behind the seat and takes a piece of everything off the king's dish before it is set down, chews it with his eyes on the middle distance, and waits. When nothing happens the king eats.

On the king's right hand, closer to him than any man in the hall, sits the Vizier.

I haven't seen Amenhotep since the hall last night. He is longer, sitting down, than most men standing: a tall thin shape in indigo linen with gold Amun signs along the hem, a collar of lapis and red stone, his shaved head banded once in gold. His hands are wrapped in strips of linen, like a man with burns, and the one thumbnail that shows is black to the root. He talks to the king in a voice too soft for me to hear, with long pauses in it, and the king nods into his plate.

He hasn't looked at me. He hasn't looked at me once, and I can feel the not-looking like a hand near the back of my neck.

Beyond him, the High Priest, lean, shaved, a leopard skin over one shoulder, counting breaths between his words. Beyond him the fat official who demanded my head last night, Userhat, sucking the meat off a bone with his eyes closed. Along the left wall, standing, Nakhtmin and a line of his guards, spears upright, still as the columns.

And by the door, at the lowest table in the hall, with the servants coming and going past his back, the Raven of Kemet, alone, with a cup.

He hadn't turned around when Hori walked me past him. He had been looking at his wine. But he'd said it, low, in the voice of a man reading from an old roll, as I passed within a foot of his shoulder:

"Watch this common occurrence."

So I watch.

I watch where he looks, which is the first thing. He is not looking at the king, or the Vizier, or the priest. He is looking two tables down the right-hand side, where a man of about forty with a green-striped collar is talking with both his hands. A broad face, a loud laugh, a wife beside him half his age with a lotus in her hair, who keeps touching his arm as if to slow him down.

Cup-bearers move along the tables with tall jars on their hips and fill cups as they go. One of them fills the Vizier's cup. One fills Userhat's. The High Priest covers his with his palm, and the bearer passes on.

The man with the green-striped collar isn't filled from a jar.

His cup comes to him on a small tray from the side of the hall, carried by a servant with a split lip badly healed, and is set down at his hand already full. He doesn't look at it. He's talking. His wife looks at it, and then at the servant, who is already gone back behind a column, and then at nothing.

The Vizier looks at him. Once, mildly, the way you'd check on bread in an oven.

The High Priest looks at the Vizier.

The same look, I think. *Before he read the scale.*

The man with the green collar finishes his sentence and laughs at it and picks up his cup and drinks half of it down.

Nothing happens for a while. The harps go around. Aneb tastes a fig. The Vizier says something to the king with a long pause in the middle of it, and the king nods.

ILLUSTRATION 5

A common occurrence: the councilor's cup, the lotus bowl, the court still eating.

FULL-PAGE PLATE. NOT YET INCLUDED.

Then the man puts his hand on the table.

Just that. Flat on the table, fingers spread, as if the room had moved. His wife says something to him. He doesn't answer. He tries to stand, and gets halfway up, and his legs go out from under him as if the strings had been cut, and he sits down hard and the table jumps and the bowl of lotus flowers slops water over the edge.

His hand goes to his throat.

He makes a sound. It's not a word. It's a sound a man makes when he has forgotten how his breathing works and is trying to remember, a long dragging pull that comes up short and tries again. His face is going dark, dark red going toward purple, and his eyes are very wide and very white in it. There is foam at the corner of his mouth. His wife has both hands on his arm now and is saying his name, and then she is saying it louder, and then she looks around the hall for someone to help her.

Nobody is looking.

I mean that exactly. Userhat is eating. The man across from him is eating. A woman three tables up laughs at something, a real laugh, with her head back. The harpists play. The cup-bearers walk their rounds. Nakhtmin stands at the wall with his face like a shut door and does not move his eyes from the far end of the room.

The man's back arches. Both his heels come off the floor and drum on it, once, twice, and his arm sweeps the table and the bronze bowl goes over and the water runs out across the wood and the lotus flowers go with it, white and pink, turning slowly in the spill, and he goes down face first into the middle of them.

He shakes for a while. Then he doesn't.

The flowers go on turning.

Two servants come from behind the columns without hurrying, and lift him under the arms, and carry him out the side door of the hall with his heels dragging, the way the assassin's arms dragged this afternoon.

His wife stands where she is with the water running off the table onto her feet.

Then the Vizier rises.

He is the tallest man in the room and the thinnest and he rises like something uncoiling, and his shadow goes up the column behind him into the dark. He walks the length of the right-hand side of the hall, unhurried, with the harps playing him down it, and he stops in front of the widow and takes both her hands in his wrapped ones and bends his long body down to her.

He smiles at her. It is a warm smile. I'm thirty feet away and I can feel the warmth of it.

He says something I can't hear. It has pauses in it. She stares at him, and then her face crumples, and she nods and nods, and she says, "Thank you, my lord." She thanks him. She thanks him twice.

Write it down, I tell myself. *All of it. The cup. The split lip. The look. The smile. The thank you.* I keep a ledger. I have kept it since the fire. It has a page for everyone who has ever decided something about my life without asking me, and the Vizier of the Two Lands has just gone onto it in ink that doesn't wash.

I'm watching the side door, where the servant with the split lip went, when I understand what my face has been doing.

Nothing.

A child would have cried out. A child would have hidden his face in the king's knee, or been sick on the floor, or screamed when the heels drummed. Every child in this hall, and there are three or four, is being held by a mother or has been hurried out. I have sat on my cushion with my hands in my lap and watched a man die for the third time in two days, and I have watched it like a man reading, and when I look up from the side door the Vizier is looking at me.

Across the whole length of the hall. Still holding the widow's hands.

His eyes are hazel, and in the lamplight they have gone to gold, and they rest on me the way they rested on the man with the green collar, mildly, checking the oven. They don't move on. The harps go around. The widow is still saying thank you.

Then he smiles at me.

It is exactly the same smile.

He has read past the child, I think. *All the way to the small print.*

A hand comes down on top of my head.

Small, warm, a little sticky with honey. The king's. He doesn't look at me. He's looking at his dish, and his other hand is on the black stone scarab at his collar, the one he touches when he's afraid, and the hand on my hair moves once, the way you'd pat a dog that has been good, so that everyone in the hall who was watching the Vizier watch me now sees a boy with a king's hand on his head.

A pet.

The gold eyes rest on us both for one more breath. Then the Vizier straightens, and lets go of the widow, and walks back up the hall to his seat, and the harps go around, and I sit under the hand of a nine-year-old who has just, without looking at me, put himself between me and the only man in Egypt who frightens him, and I don't know yet whether to be grateful or afraid.

Both. The answer is both. It's always going to be both.

✦ ✦ ✦

The Raven is waiting in the dark of the corridor outside, where the lamps don't reach.

"Well?"

I tell him. The cup that came full. The split lip. The look from the priest to the Vizier, the same look as at the scale. The way nobody stopped eating. The smile. The two thank yous. The hand on my head.

"Why did the king do that?"

I’ve been thinking about it the whole way down the hall.

“To make me a pet again,” I say. “In front of the Vizier. Because the Vizier had stopped seeing one.”

Nakhti is quiet for a long time. Somewhere behind us the harps have started a new song that sounds like the old one.

“This is the truth of the royal palace,” he says. “Come. You’ve seen it. Now I’ll tell you what it means.” ## 5 · The First Lesson

Nakhti’s room is three turns past the House of Life and no bigger than mine. A mat, a lamp, a shelf of rolls, a jar of wine on the floor with a cup beside it. On the wall above the mat, hung on two pegs where another man would hang a god, is a bronze dagger with a crack running through the blade from the point to the hilt.

He doesn’t explain it. I don’t ask.

He pours wine and drinks half of it standing and sits down on the floor with the cup, and I see the thing in him that the wine is for, and I put that in the ledger too, on his page, which I have just started.

“Sit,” he says. “Not there. Where you can see the door.”

I move.

He takes a handful of date stones out of a dish and sets one on the floor between us, alone, in the circle of the lamp.

“The king.”

Another, long and thin, close beside it. Closer than any of the others will be.

“The Vizier. He holds the king’s seal in everything but his hand. Every order in Kemet goes through him. Grain, soldiers, judges, the dead. He was a scribe once. Men who were scribes know that whoever holds the pen holds what is true.”

A third stone, on the other side of the king.

“The High Priest of Amun.”

“What is his name?”

"Names are paid for in this palace, child. You will have his when you can afford it." He sets a fourth stone, fat, a little apart. "Userhat. The treasury. He wanted your head last night because the Vizier wanted to see whether the king would give it. The king didn't. Userhat will remember that you cost him something. Fat men remember."

A fifth, by the door of the circle, standing up on its end.

"Nakhtmin. The Shield of the Living Pharaoh. Three hundred men in the palace and the only blades inside these walls that aren't the Vizier's. He takes his orders from the Vizier, as the Vizier takes his from the king, as the king takes his from the gods. Ask yourself which of those is true."

"Does he hate it?"

"Ask me again in a year."

Two more stones, far outside the lamplight, almost at the wall.

"Horemheb. Great Commander of the Army, in the north, with every soldier in Kemet who has ever seen a Hittite. He has not come south in two years. And Ay. God's Father. He taught the old king's children their letters and he keeps to his estates at Akhmim and he says nothing. Silence is also a side. Remember that one."

Ay. On the chart over my bed, in my mother's handwriting, the name after Tut's. The man who gets the throne when the boy is nineteen. I look at the little stone by the wall and I feel the cold go through me that I felt in the hall when the herald read out the cartouche.

I know how this ends. I'm the only one in the room who does, and it's the one thing I can never say.

"Land," Nakhti says, and draws a line through the dust with his finger around the priest's stone, a big circle. "The temple of Amun holds a third of the fields in the Black Land since the restoration, and the temple's grain goes where the High Priest says." A smaller circle around the king and the Vizier together. "The king's fields. The Vizier administers them. The nomarchs in the provinces owe both and love

neither.” He taps the standing stone. “Soldiers, you’ve seen. Temples, you’ve seen. That is the whole of the palace. Three things, and who holds them.”

“And you, my lord?”

“Me.” He picks up a stone and holds it, and then puts it back in the dish instead of on the floor. “The old king found me in a slave gang on a canal and decided I could count. He made me a scribe, and then a steward, and then an advisor, and the whole court has spent ten years waiting for him to be proved wrong. He’s dead. They’re still waiting.” He drinks. “Now listen, because I’ll say this once and you’ll hear it every day of your life after.”

He holds up one black finger.

“Never show your real thoughts. You failed that tonight, before the whole court, and a widow was still saying thank you when you did it.”

A second finger.

“Never trust beauty or kindness. The Vizier was kind to a widow tonight. You saw what the kindness cost. Everything beautiful in this palace was put there to be looked at while something else happens.”

A third.

“Never forget the cost of each lie you tell. You’re going to tell a great many, child. I can see it on you. Every one of them is a stone you carry, and one day you’ll be thrown in the river, and you’ll find out what you weigh.”

Three, I think. *I’ve already broken the third one with you, and we’re not an hour in.*

“Now. Two Egypts live in this palace.” He sweeps his hand once over the stones, dividing them. “The Vizier’s. The seal, the treasury, the scribes, the Medjay in the city, and the priesthood of Amun leaning his way like a wall leans before it goes over. That Egypt is the one with the grain in it.” The hand comes back. “The king’s. The king. A slave with a burned face. Three hundred guards under a commander whose orders

come from the other side. A few old servants who remember his father. Me.” The green eye lifts. “And you. Whether you want it or not. Because the king put his hand on your head tonight in front of everyone, and the Vizier saw him do it, and in this palace a thing that is seen has happened.”

“Who do I beware of?”

“Everyone. But if you want a list: Userhat, who is stupid and owed. The Vizier’s steward, who has soft hands and does hard things with them. The servant with the split lip, whom you’ve met. The priests who come to purify a room after a death, because they also come before.” He pauses, and turns the copper ring. “And a man who comes and goes from the Vizier’s house at night with his face covered, who smells of myrrh and something burnt. I don’t know his name. No one does. If you ever smell him, child, walk the other way.”

“And who do I trust?”

“No one.”

“You?”

“I’m the one teaching you not to.” He almost smiles. “Hori, then. The soldier who pulled you out of the river and fed you. A man who feeds a prisoner is either kind or ordered. Find out which before you eat again.”

I look at the stones for a while. The lamp hisses. Somewhere in the palace a door closes, and I count the echo, four, which means a courtyard, which means the second court, which means the way I came.

“Why does the Vizier need the attempts to be seen?”

“Does he?”

“The man stopped and looked at the door. He wanted an audience. Three this season, and all three cut down by the Commander before they could speak, and the Commander answers to the Vizier.” I’m talking faster than I should. I can hear it. “A king who is afraid signs what he’s handed. Every attempt needs a name, and every name the

Vizier gives it is a man he's removed. And every time, it's the Vizier's commander who saved the king, so every time, it was the Vizier who saved the king. He doesn't need the king dead. He needs the king to need him."

Nakhti doesn't say anything.

"Who told you that?" he says, finally.

"You did. You didn't say it."

"The gods whisper to those who listen," he says, slowly. "Wisdom hides in silence, not in shouting. You listen well, child. You shout a little. We'll work on it." He drinks. "And the councilor? Since you've been so busy."

"Kanefer." I'd heard the wife say it, over and over, before she stopped. "He asked a question in council this morning."

"Did he."

"You said a man who asks a question dies. The fan-bearer asked one. I'd guess his was about grain, since the Vizier's Egypt is the one with the grain in it, and the temple's circle on your floor is bigger than the king's."

The green eye doesn't blink.

"He asked why the temple of Amun's tallies have grown for three floods," Nakhti says, "while the army's have shrunk, with Hatti at the door of Djahy."

"Three floods."

"Three."

"Since the old king died."

He goes very still. The lamp hisses. The cracked dagger on the wall throws a shadow with a crack in it.

"Since the old king died," he says, and it isn't a question, and I understand that I've just stepped on something I can't see the shape of yet, a thing under the sand that this man has been walking around for three years with his eye on the ground.

He sets down the cup. He looks at me the way he looked at me in the House of Life when the pen stopped, straight at the face, not up and down, and I let him, and I think of the three things he just told me never to do, and I keep my real thoughts behind my eyes, where they belong, and I say nothing.

It is the first thing I've done right all day.

"You have the body of a child," says the Raven of Kemet, "but you listen like a man who has already lost something. Wisdom like that is rare. And in this palace, it's dangerous."